Chapter 3 · Story

One broken toaster becomes “they always break.”

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



The story that comes to mind · c03s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

What most improves the estimate of repeat failures?

A A detailed account of the worst failure.

B Failures divided by comparable completed repairs.

C A vote on whose impression feels realistic.

Suggested answer: B. The total of comparable repairs provides the denominator for a failure rate. Consistent follow-up still matters.

Memorable is not the same as common.

- **Availability heuristic**: easy-to-recall examples shape judgment.
- **Base rate**: how common is it among comparable cases?
- **Denominator**: total comparable repairs, including successes.

A failure rate needs the whole record

“That toaster failed again!”

Invented record: all comparable repairs



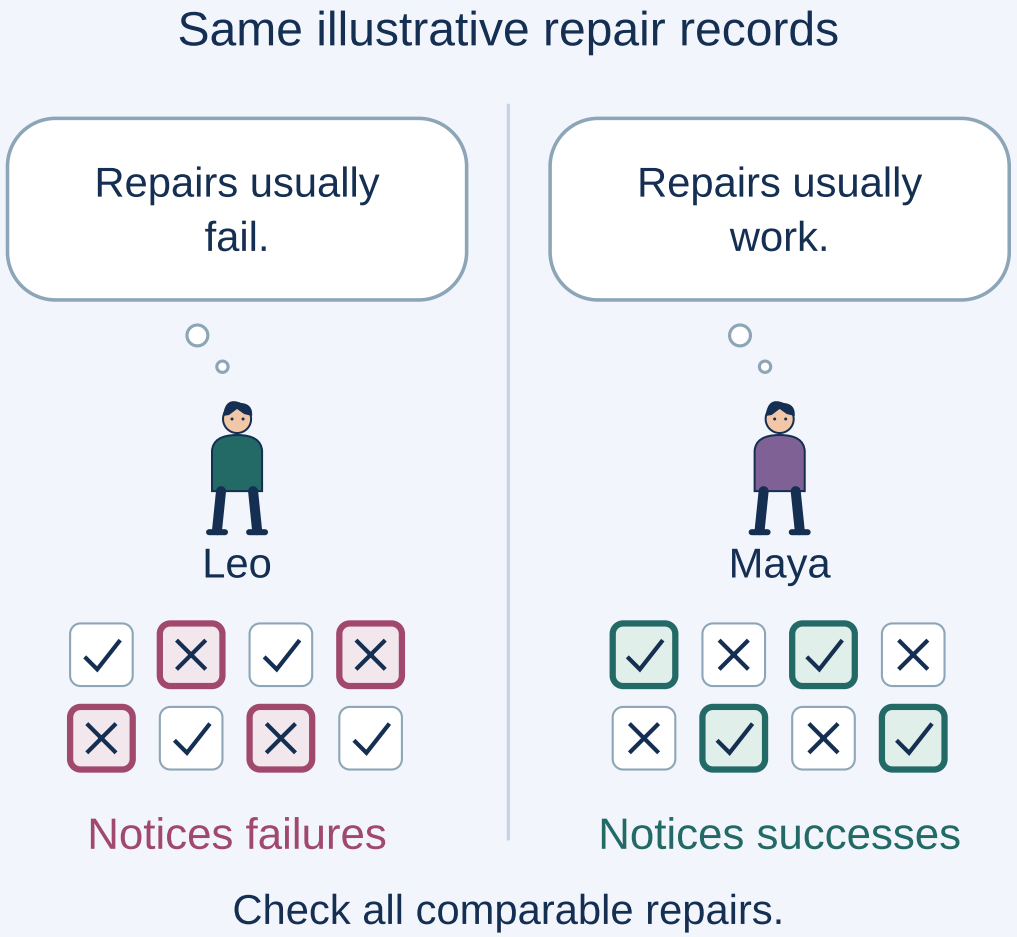
4 failures / 40 repairs = 10%

Availability is a shortcut, not a frequency count.

The invented whole record gives a vivid case its denominator.

Give a belief a fair test.

- **Confirmation bias**: seeking or interpreting evidence to fit a belief.
- Leo expects evening sessions to fail.
- Count comparable successes as well as failures.
- **Ask**: what outcome could change Leo’s view?



Expectations can change which evidence gets attention.

When a desired answer feels persuasive.

- **Motivated reasoning**: what we want to be true can shape evaluation.
- Maya wants the café's repairs to succeed.
- Use one definition of failure for every case.
- Invite a review that could challenge the preferred answer.

A desired conclusion can shape reasoning

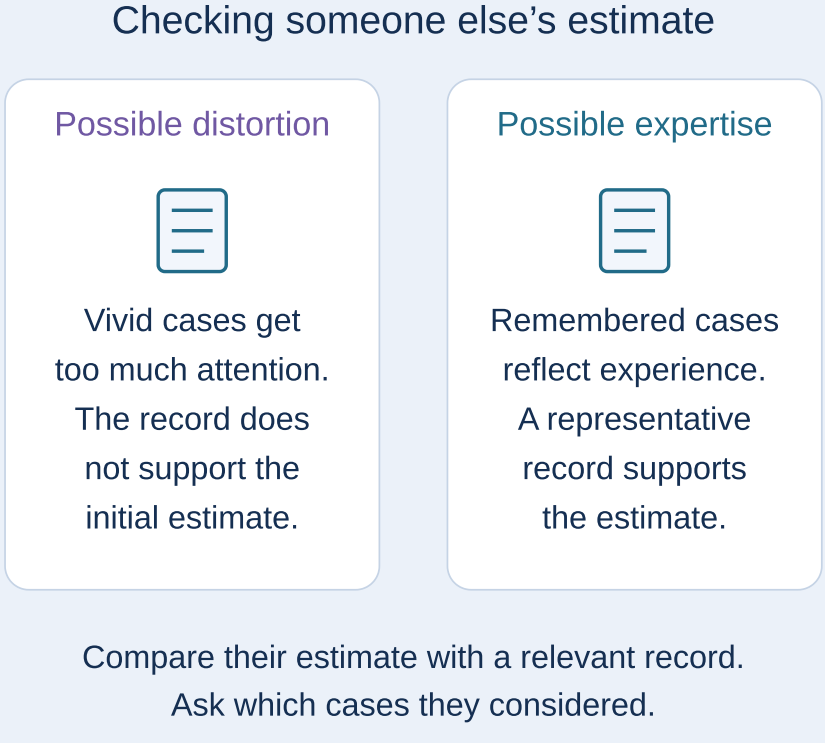
1. **Maya wants the café to succeed**
   "I hope our repairs are working."
2. **Reassuring stories feel persuasive**
   Returns get less attention
3. **Maya can use one test for all cases**
   Define failure and follow up consistently
4. **Maya can invite a challenging review**
   What could change her first belief?

A wanted conclusion can still be correct.

Maya's desired outcome may shape how she judges the evidence.

What can we really conclude?

When assessing someone else’s estimate, compare that estimate with a relevant record before proposing that it is biased. A bias label alone cannot establish how the person reached the estimate. For example, Leo’s vivid repair stories might give a distorted impression of failure. In another case, an experienced repairer’s remembered cases might accurately reflect a dependable record. Representative evidence helps distinguish these possibilities. When reviewing another person’s reasoning, ask which information they used and which cases they missed. Disagreeing with their estimate does not replace that investigation. Experts also need feedback and opportunities to revise their judgments.



Compare another person’s estimate with the record behind it.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Leo thinks evening sessions fail. Which question best challenges his belief?

A Which evenings went badly?

B Who agrees that evenings are a poor idea?

C What outcomes would make us conclude evenings work?

Suggested answer: C. Naming outcomes that would count as success gives Leo’s belief a chance to be wrong.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Why can’t Leo estimate the repair failure rate from one vivid toaster failure? What total must he count?

> When can an availability shortcut be useful?

1. The denominator is the total of comparable cases. Four failed repairs mean something different among forty repairs than among four hundred. Consistent follow-up is needed to estimate the failure rate.

2. An availability shortcut can help when the examples that come to mind reliably represent the relevant events.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Keep a small record of one everyday prediction for a week. Include successes and failures. Avoid collecting private information about others. Compare the whole record with your first impression.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.